

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



After earning both his undergraduate and master's degrees from the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Ralph Wanger began a career as a computer programmer. "I worked at an insurance company," he recalls, "with a two-million-dollar machine that couldn't do as much as one of today's three-thousand-dollar desktops." But finding he wasn't cut out for the painstaking detail work of a programmer, in 1961 he landed a job as a security analyst at a small Chicago brokerage house, Harris Associates. Before long he was managing some customer accounts, and succeeding so well at it that when the firm launched a mutual fund in 1970, the Acorn Fund, Wanger was asked to run it. He built an outstanding record investing in small, rapidly growing companies, and when he formed his own firm, Wanger Asset Management, in 1992, Acorn's board of directors decided he should continue as the fund's manager. Later that year, drawing on its expertise in investing in foreign stocks for Acorn, the new firm launched Acorn International Fund. Still later came Acorn USA, which invests only in domestic stocks, and two variable annuities, Wanger Asset Trust USA and International. His funds' shareholders have had an added bonus over the years: Wanger's quarterly letters, widely known for their wit and far-ranging subject matter. All told, today Wanger Asset Management is responsible for more than five billion dollars in investments. Wanger, now 62, lives in Chicago with his wife, Leah Zell, a Harvard Ph.D. and partner in Wanger Asset Management, and their two daughters. He has three children from a previous marriage.